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Cynthia D. McCauley, EDITOR

Morgan W. McCall, Jr., EDITOR

Using Experience to Develop Leadership Talent

How Organizations Leverage
On-the-Job Development



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**How Organizations Leverage
On-the-Job Development**

Cynthia D. McCauley

Morgan W. McCall, Jr.

Editors

Forewords by Allan I. Kraut, Moheet Nagrath,
and Inge G. Thulin

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CHAPTER SIX

Leading from Where You Are

Driving On-the-Job Development into the Whole Organization

Paul R. Yost

One of the hot topics in organizations today is integrated talent management. Unfortunately, more often than not this topic is transformed into one of three practices: (1) a company-wide competency model that ignores the importance of experience, (2) a top-down approach that inevitably leads to the quagmire, “Before we do anything, let’s make sure it is all integrated,” or (3) a perfect plan that fails to survive the next company reorganization.

Unfortunately, organizations today seldom stay still long enough to integrate anything. We live in an age of highly complex, dynamic organizations where change is the rule rather than the exception; what some have christened VUCA environments (Volatile, Uncertain, Complex, Ambiguous; Johansen, 2009). The market changes, technology changes, a new CEO is hired, a new vice president of human resources is appointed, or a new business strategy is launched. Suddenly, the grand plans for an integrated talent management process have to be scrapped and the work has to start over.

In addition to a dynamic environment, most industrial-organizational (I-O) psychologists and human resource (HR) professionals have to lead from the middle. The majority of on-the-job development initiatives are likely to be launched within a

single HR process (e.g., succession planning, performance management, leadership training programs) and often within a specific geography, business unit, or a targeted employee group (e.g., first-level managers).

The purpose of this chapter is to explore how I-O and HR professionals can build on-the-job development initiatives that start in one place but are crafted in a way that promotes the adoption and spread of experience-based development throughout the whole organization. Rather than waiting to build on-the-job development into the organization from the top down, a more effective strategy in a dynamic organization is to build experience-based development initiatives that thrive in these kinds of environments. The secret is to create programs that are designed as catalysts, promoting experience-based development throughout the organization. Leading from where you are means building on-the-job development initiatives in a way that can “go viral” and “infect” the talent management processes and systems throughout the organization. The first half of the chapter will explore five design factors that are likely to increase the spread and sustainability of on-the-job development initiatives. The second half of the chapter will illustrate how the five factors can be applied within three HR systems: succession planning, performance management, and relationship-based development processes such as communities of practice.

Five Design Characteristics for Viral On-the-Job Development Initiatives

I-O and HR professionals are influenced by several fields that tend to emphasize a top-down approach: strategic human resources (Becker & Huslid, 2006; Lawler, 2003; Ulrich & Brockbank, 2005), project management (Westerveld, 2003; White & Fortune, 2002), and change management (Cummings & Worley, 2008; Kotter, 1995). All three often begin by talking about the importance of starting at the top—enlisting senior management support—and then cascading the initiatives down through the organization. But relying on a top-down approach can be counter-productive in today’s organizations, where change is often the rule, not the exception. The external environment can change, the

organization's priorities can change, and the people at the "top" can change. CEO tenure has decreased in recent years, with 40 percent of CEOs leaving their jobs after only 1.8 years (Gottfredson, Schaubert, & Saenz, 2008). This is not necessarily a new trend. Ciampa and Watkins (1999) tracked the success rates of ninety-four COOs who were brought in to eventually move into the senior role. Five years later, twenty-two had left the company and 75 percent had not made it to the top as expected. Top management is only one example of the typical obstacles and dynamic changes that interventions are likely to face externally (e.g., the entry of new competitors, markets getting worse, markets getting better, and technology changes) and internally (e.g., corporate reorganizations, changes in HR leadership, time pressures, and competing priorities).

Furthermore, approaches that start at the top often underestimate the role of people in the middle of the organization. Historically, civil rights movements across the globe would not have happened if people waited for "top management support." Minority voices and groups can create change if they are confident, consistent, and sustained (Hogg, 2010; Sharp, 2010; Wood, Lundgren, Ouellette, Busceme, & Blackstone, 1994). Recent work has begun to identify the factors that predict the adoption, adaptability, and sustainability of organizational innovations (Ansari, Fiss, & Zajac, 2010; Kossek, 1987, 1989; Som, 2007; Wolfe, 1995; Yost, McLellan, Ecker, Chang, Hereford, Roenicke, et al., 2011).

To drive change from the middle, HR professionals need a different approach and a different set of tools. The person who leads from the middle needs to think of himself or herself as a catalyst for change. This is all the more true in today's highly networked and dynamic environment where how ideas and processes are crafted are good predictors of which ones will be the most likely to gain traction over time (Heath & Heath, 2007; Weick, 1984).

Furthermore, organizational changes are often iterative and incremental, but can still be significant over time (Bellman, 1992; Frohman, 1997; Reay, Golden-Biddle, & Bermann, 2006). Iterative changes can also fail. They need to be designed in a way that will increase adaptation and growth over time (Weick,

1984; Yost et al., 2011). Five design characteristics are particularly important:

- *Strategic*: Does the on-the-job development initiative align with and support the business strategy?
- *Simple*: Are the processes and tools simple and easy to use? Do they make the manager's job easier? Do they make the end-user's job easier? Do they avoid "HR speak"?
- *Sneeze-able*: Are the process and tools "sticky" (i.e., do people *want* to use them?) and are they sneeze-able (i.e., do people want to *pass them on*)?
- *Systemic*: Are the processes and tools designed so they can be easily integrated into other HR processes in the organization? That is, are they crafted in a way that complements and enhances other talent management processes within the organization? Will other business and HR systems be able to easily integrate them?
- *Sustainable*: Are the processes and tools built in a way that is sustainable? That is, do they require continued investment and energy or are they self-sustaining, able to adapt to changing conditions in the organization?

Other characteristics are, of course, also important to consider when crafting and implementing on-the-job development interventions (e.g., cost, execution, resources), but these five characteristics play a particularly important role in building on-the-job development initiatives that will be self-sustaining and are likely to grow and spread.

An Executive On-Boarding Program That Is Strategic, Simple, Sneeze-able, Systemic, and Sustainable

Let's begin with an example. Imagine an HR generalist who is charged with the task of building a process to help new executives who are joining the business unit. From research, we know that transitions are ideal times for leaders to learn how to leverage experiences and build a set of learning capabilities that will increase their capacity to capture the lessons of experience in

future challenges. For example, leaders can learn how to take on and navigate through stretch assignments, the importance of seeking feedback, reflection to capture the lessons, and the importance of developmental relationships.

Imagine that one of the tools created is an executive on-boarding checklist. A very specific process can be designed for these leaders, but the impact is likely to be limited to one group of employees in one business unit. However, the processes and tools in the executive on-boarding intervention could alternatively be crafted in a way that is more likely to be picked up and integrated into other HR processes within the organization (e.g., a new employee orientation, new manager training, leadership development programs).

Exhibit 6.1 provides of an example of how this information might be turned into a checklist that the new executives could

Exhibit 6.1. Executive On-Boarding Transition Checklist

My Transition Checklist

My Manager

I have met with my manager, and we have done the following:

- ☐ Discussed my goals for the coming year and how my success will be measured.
- ☐ Identified the key stakeholders who will be critical to my success.
- ☐ Discussed the challenges and barriers that I will face and my manager's ideas on how I might address them.
- ☐ Identified the resources that I will need to be successful.
- ☐ Noted the small wins I will accomplish in the first thirty to ninety days.
- ☐ Discussed the ways that I want to develop in the coming year and my long-term career aspirations.

My Direct Reports (if in a supervisory position)

- ☐ I have set up meetings with my team to discuss:
 - Their thoughts about the team's strengths and areas for improvement.

- Their individual jobs and performance goals for the coming year.
- Their long-term development goals.
- ☐ I have scheduled regular 1:1 meetings with each of my direct reports.

My Network

- ☐ I have identified the key stakeholders in this new role (e.g., senior leaders, thought leaders, peers, key people in other departments, customers, suppliers) and have scheduled times to meet with each of them.
- ☐ I have identified the people I need to meet with regularly in this job and set up ongoing meetings with each of them.
- ☐ I have met with at least two other executives who have recently joined the company.

Feedback and Reflection

- ☐ I have identified some natural places during the day and throughout the year to reflect on how I'm doing, what's working and what's not, and where I want to go from there.
- ☐ I have asked my boss and at least two other people to give me feedback if they see me start to veer off course. I have reminders on my calendar to ask for feedback every two weeks.

use to ensure they are setting themselves up for success in their new jobs. The checklist is designed in a way that is useful for the targeted initiative and the five design characteristics have been incorporated in a way that should increase the adoption and spread of the tool.

Strategic. Both scholars and practitioners have noted that HR processes—and experience-based development initiatives by extension—are significantly more likely to be accepted when they are closely aligned with the business strategy (Becker & Huslid, 2006; Lawler, 2003; Lengnick-Hall, Lengnick-Hall, Andrade, & Drake, 2009; McCall, 2010). Based on this principle, experience-based leadership development is more likely to be picked up when it is discussed in the context of organizational goals and

what leaders will need to meet future strategic challenges. Leadership development becomes a fully integrated and fundamental part of achieving the business strategy (McCall, 2010). Leaders are developed when they are put in roles where they can execute the business strategy and develop themselves *at exactly the same time* (Yost & Plunkett, 2009, 2010).

In the case of an executive on-boarding program, the on-boarding process should be seen as good business, not as another HR process. The guidance and support materials should be crafted with this same strategic focus. The checklist should be perceived as a tool that senior executives can use to start driving results as soon as possible. The materials should use business language and be based on the factors that research has found are critical to successful on-boarding. For example, in our field, we know that it is critical for new leader to set goals, to identify and connect with key stakeholders, and to seek feedback from other people. All of these should be part of the checklist. However, the way they are discussed and positioned will often determine whether the guidance is used. For example, the transition checklist should probably not talk about “setting performance goals,” but instead should use the language of executives, such as “determine how your success will be measured in this job.” Similarly, the checklist should probably avoid using language that states the executive should “identify his or her developmental network” and instead direct the leader to “identify and meet with the key stakeholders who will be critical to your success.” The differences are subtle, but important.

Simple. On-the-job development processes and tools should be simple and easy to use. Are they concrete with clear actions that the leader can take? Do they make the leader’s job easier? This is not to say they should be simplistic. Any process or tool might include significant complexity behind the scenes, but the user interface that the person sees should be simple and easy to understand—think Apple products.

For example, the executive transition checklist should ideally be no more than a page. Of course, there are countless activities that an executive needs to consider to succeed in a new job, but a longer checklist is unlikely to be read. The on-boarding checklist is only one piece of information in the deluge of other

priorities that will compete for the executive's attention. A short checklist will be used.

Sneeze-able. Are the on-the-job development processes and tools “sticky” (Gladwell, 2000; Heath & Heath, 2007); that is, do people want to use them? Are they tools that you would want to use? The on-the-job development processes and tools should be so compelling that leaders would be stupid not to use them. Beyond just sticky, the on-the-job development processes and tools also should be “sneeze-able” (Godin, 2001); that is, the experience-based development systems and tools should be so compelling that people want to pass them on to others. Sneeze-able processes and tools are self-contained, that is, standalone tools that don't require the user to understand a larger context (e.g., a leader doesn't need to reference other information to understand and use them). They should also be designed to promote interactions with others to encourage their proliferation into the larger system. For example, a transition checklist could include a suggestion to connect with other new executives who have recently joined the company.

Continuing with the transition checklist as the example, a sneeze-able checklist will be able to stand on its own and does not require the user to consult any other materials. The temptation will be to make the checklist part of a larger on-boarding process, which will naturally draw the person crafting it to reference the other elements of the process. The checklist should be written in a way that complements other processes, but it should be designed as a standalone tool (see also the discussion about building systemic processes below). As you build the tool, consider using first person—focus on what the user wants. Build a checklist with items that one would be crazy to ignore (e.g., Why wouldn't a leader want to talk to his or her manager to identify a list of the key stakeholders in his or her new job?). A great indicator of the transitions “sneeze-ability” is if leaders do, in fact, pass it on to colleagues and new members who join their teams. When you are done, ask yourself, “Is this a checklist that I would want to use as I begin my next job? Will I really use it?”

To further illustrate, consider the following additional sneeze-able development tool examples. In a former company, I was part of an executive assessment process that required senior leaders

to perform card sorts with the leadership competencies and derailment factors for leaders in the company. At the end of the meetings, leaders often asked whether they could “get a set of those cards” for their own use. In another company, colleagues and I created a one-page “*Reader’s Digest*” quiz called “Development Plans That Aren’t a Waste of Time” with items that were in people’s self-interest (e.g., I am developing skills that will be in demand three to five years from now; I get excited when I look at my development plan). When people finished the quiz, they looked up what their score indicated. People who scored toward the lower end of the scale received the rather draconian statement: “You are likely to finish the year less employable than you started it.” The quiz went viral because it was personal and simple to pass on to others. In the following weeks, we discovered that several managers were forwarding a link to the quiz to their employees during the performance management cycle, asking employees to use the checklist as they put their development plans together.

Systemic. Even though the on-the-job development processes and tools should stand on their own, they should be designed in a way that will complement and enhance other talent management processes in the organization. Integrated talent management systems do not need to be complex, top-down hierarchical systems; other organizational models are available (e.g., Kates, 2006; McKenna & Wright, 1992; Vosburgh, 2007). The World Wide Web might be a better metaphor—separate entities that complement, combine, and sometimes compete with each other. Or think LegosTM or hamster Habitrail components that can exist as standalone products but can be combined with other components. In a dynamic and connected ecosystem, the challenge is to create a process that complements and is easy to attach to other processes.

Taking the executive on-boarding checklist as an example, as it is being crafted, the secret is to identify the other talent management processes where it might be used and build the checklist so it will be picked up by other processes. For example, could the checklist be written in a way that could be used in the organization’s employee orientation process? Could it be used in a manager training program for new supervisors? As you build the checklist,

use language that would apply to leaders at multiple leadership levels and in multiple locations in the organization.

Sustainable. To maximize the sustainability of on-the-job development interventions, they should be designed in a way that will require as little ongoing energy and as few resources as possible. New priorities and new work will always threaten to overwhelm ongoing work. Ideally, the intervention should be built so it will be self-sustaining and self-adapting to emerging business realities. The critical question becomes: “Did I build the on-the-job development intervention in a way that will outlast me?” In a series of critical incident interviews, Yost and colleagues (2011) interviewed sixteen senior I-O and HR professionals, asking them to identify HR interventions that had lasted for ten or more years and then describe the organizational, intervention, and change leader characteristics that allowed the intervention to survive. One of the interesting findings was that some of the top-down factors emerged, but the initiative leaders emphasized the role that they played in proactively making them happen. For example, the change leaders talked about the importance of proactively involving key stakeholders and end-users in the process, recruiting sponsors from key business units, and engaging top management when opportunities arise. The top-down factors were important, but they were often led from the middle. The classic example is the HR professional, who in a conversation with a senior leader, plants an idea that eventually becomes the leader’s idea.

On-the-job development interventions that will have organization-wide impact need to be built not only to survive, but also built to thrive in environments where the future is unknown and often unknowable. Weick (1984) proposed that the best strategy in an environment where sensemaking is limited may be to focus on building small wins. He proposed that optimal small wins are discrete, self-contained actions with a high probability of success that can serve as stable building blocks for future actions. The small wins allow successes to build on one another, learning what works and what doesn’t, and iteratively using this information to adapt to new emerging challenges.

Going back to the executive on-boarding transition example, the transition checklist could serve as one of the discrete building

blocks in introducing on-the-job development into an organization. Other building blocks might include creating a peer mentoring process whereby new executives can meet to discuss challenges and lessons learned, or providing guidance on common derailers and how to avoid them. The executives who utilize the transition process also represent potential building blocks as they advocate for and model the importance of on-the-job development strategies in working with others. How the process and tools are crafted will also impact the sustainability. Are the processes and tools built so they can be modified and adapted over time? Have key stakeholder groups been engaged in the rollout (e.g., the HR generalists who support the leaders)? Can you conduct a pilot project in the business unit of a senior leader who is recognized for developing others? How can you use the pilot to increase the visibility of on-the-job development and create a “pull” in other areas of the organization? Remember that the ultimate goal is to build a process that is scalable and will outlast you.

Building On-the-Job Development into Organizational Talent Management Systems

The five design characteristics provide a framework for building on-the-job development initiatives that are more likely to have a broad, deep, and long-term impact within an organization. In the following section, strategies for integrating on-the-job development into three talent management processes are reviewed: succession planning, performance management, and communities of practice. Each section begins with specific ideas on how on-the-job development can be integrated into the process and then explores how the five design characteristics can be used to broaden the impact of the interventions into the larger organization.

Succession Management

Because of its high visibility, succession management is an ideal place for an organization to begin building experience-based development into an organization’s DNA. At its best, succession management is about experience-based development—strategically placing

aspiring leaders in assignments that will stretch and develop them for more senior roles. The succession planning process is a natural place for the critical leadership experiences to be defined and to then become a platform to spread them to other leaders in the organization. Regrettably, most succession planning processes focus the preponderance of their attention on candidate selection and relatively less attention on development (Karaevli & Hall, 2003). This is unfortunate, since there is a natural pull for other leaders to look to the succession planning process to discover the experiences that are most valued in the organization and use the information to chart their own development. Several corporations—PepsiCo (Church & Waclawski, 2010), Microsoft (Yost, 2010), and HEINEKEN (Plunkett, 2013) among others—have explicitly included developmental experiences in their succession planning processes.

There are a variety of ways that on-the-job development can be built into the succession planning process. Key developmental experiences can be built into the succession candidate profiles, for example, rating candidates on the extent to which they have had key leadership experiences such as leading a start-up, turning a business around, global assignments, and key business unit or functional experience. (See Yost and Plunkett, 2010, for suggestions on how to identify critical experiences in an organization and build them into an organization's succession planning processes.) Beyond identifying the experiences, the succession planning process also serves as a signal for the leadership behaviors that are rewarded in the organization (e.g., Are leaders promoted for performance or for performance and developing the people in their organization?).

Despite the potential, many organizations fail to use the succession management process to spark on-the-job development in the larger organization. The five design principles discussed above provide guidance on ways to leverage on-the-job development initiatives in the succession planning process to plant seeds in the larger organization. For example, as senior executives discuss the future challenges that the organization is facing, they can also discuss the leadership experiences and competencies that will be needed (strategic). A description of the key leadership experiences that are assessed in the succession process could be created

and made more broadly available in the organization (simple, sneeze-able).

As the experiences are being created, the developers should define the experiences broadly enough that they also apply at lower leadership levels. For example, what does a start-up experience look like for senior leaders and for first-level managers (e.g., starting up a new division versus building a team from scratch)? The broader definitions will enhance the capacity for and likelihood that the leadership experiences will be integrated into other processes such as employee development plans (systemic). A matrix could be created mapping the key experiences to the competencies and lessons that are most likely to be learned in the experience (see Figure 6.1; simple, sneeze-able). Put the experiences and other tools on the company intranet so everyone can access them and so they can easily be linked into other talent management processes.

Performance Management

Employee development plans are the talent management process that will touch the broadest range of employees and an obvious place where on-the-job-development should be highlighted. Unfortunately, the development planning process “required by HR” can also be one of the most maligned and underutilized talent management processes within organizations. Employee development plans are often a box that appears at the bottom of the goal-setting form, a place to put the training classes that you want the company to pay for, or the paperwork that HR requires everybody to fill out every year. The typical instructions that accompany the forms don’t help, often reading like a tax form (see Exhibit 6.2 on pages 128–129).

How can the performance management process be used to encourage on-the-job development? Sometimes all that managers and employees need is a list of on-the-job development ideas. Exhibit 6.3 provides an example of how simple the lists can be. Several sources are available with a variety of on-the-job development examples that can be adapted and tailored to match the language used in different organizations (e.g., Lombardo & Eichinger, 1988; McCauley, 2006; Simons, 2005). Alternatively,

Figure 6.1. Experience by Lessons Matrix

	1. Running the Business	Thinking Strategically	Innovative Problem Solving	Learning How the Business Works	Understanding the Customer	Shouldering Full Responsibility	2. Managing People	Engaging and Directing Others	Building a Team That Works Together	Relying on Others' Talents and Expertise	Developing Others	Understanding Others' Perspectives	Managing Through Multiple Levels	3. Working Across the Business	Collaboration and Cooperation	Dealing with Conflict	Political Savvy	Working with Senior Leaders	Strategies of Negotiation
1. Setting the Stage																			
Early Work Experience		○	◆	◆	○	◆		○	○			◆	◆		◆	◆			
First Supervisory Experience		◆		○				◆	◆	◆	○	◆			◆	◆			
2. Leading on the Line																			
Starting Something from Scratch		◆	○	◆				○	○										
Turning a Business Around			○		◆			◆	◆	◆	○	◆				◆			
External Relations		○	◆		◆			◆	○						◆	◆			◆
Global Experience					◆			○	○			◆	◆		◆			◆	
3. Leading by Persuasion																			
Project/Task Force Assignment		◆	○					◆	○	◆					◆			◆	
Functional/Staff Role		○	○					○			◆						○		
Integration Role		◆		○					○			○							
4. Other																			
Good & Bad Role Models		○						○											
Peer Hardships																			
Duration			○	○															

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organizations might define the key challenges or experiences at different proficiency levels so leaders and employees can easily adapt them to their own job situations (see Exhibit 6.4).

Including simple instructions at the beginning of a development plan can often make a significant difference in what people include as development activities. For example, the development plan instructions could refer to the ubiquitous “70–20–10 Rule” for development (70 percent of development occurs on the job, 20 percent from other people, and 10 percent in training) to encourage employees to include more on-the-job activities in

Exhibit 6.2. HR Tools at Their Worst**Employee Development Plans at Company X**

Instructions in Brief: Your ongoing development and improvement to your time at Company X. Every year employees are asked to complete an Employee Development and Performance Plan (EDPP). Prior to the actual feedback session, the supervisor schedules a time to discuss with the employee the Employee Development and Performance Plan (EDPP), as itemized below. The amount of time between the Preview Session and the Feedback Session should be reasonable and adequate to allow appropriate preparation of the EDPP.

1. Carefully review the EDPP Instructions as well as any specific agency policies or procedures.
2. Ensure a mutual understanding of the process and timing that will be followed.
3. Review the position description (classification questionnaire) to ensure accuracy of stated duties and responsibilities. . . .”

Exhibit 6.3. List of Developmental Activities**Turning a Business Around**

- Volunteer to take on and work with one of the department’s most dissatisfied customers.
- Lead a cost-cutting initiative.
- Champion a change your group has been resisting.
- Lead a quality improvement project for a product or process.
- Take over a project that hasn’t succeeded in the past.
- Take over a failing business unit.

Starting a Project from Scratch

- Volunteer to lead a project that requires building a new process.
- Find work that is currently “falling through the cracks” in your organization and volunteer to solve it.
- Take on a project that requires you to build the team and make it successful.

- Visit a customer's site.
- Find ways to work with customers and clients in new markets.
- Work on a strategic plan for a non-profit organization.
- Lead a business that is entering a new market.

Leading Without Authority

- Organize a networking group to study a "hot" topic in your organization.
- Take on projects that will require you to influence other departments without any formal authority.
- Ask your boss to delegate the leadership of one of the team's tasks to you.
- Lead a cross-company initiative that requires you to work across multiple departments and/or business units.
- Lead a virtual team.
- Take on a staffing or corporate role that requires building processes and systems across multiple organizations.

Learning from Other People

- Find a mentor and meet with him or her monthly.
- Volunteer to serve on a team that is functionally or globally diverse.
- Become a mentor for someone else.
- Identify three people who can provide feedback in an area you are trying to develop.
- Create an informal working group to discuss new trends and challenges facing people in your business.

their development plans. (Interestingly, research suggests that these percentages do not necessarily hold for women and minorities, who report that other people play a greater role in their development [Douglas, 2003; Van Velsor & Hughes-James, 1990]).

Combining the instructions with specific examples can also serve as a powerful catalyst to promote a stronger focus on experience-based development (e.g., "As you plan for your development in the coming year, remember that the best development comes from on-the-job assignments that stretch you in the areas you have targeted for development. For example, volunteer to

Exhibit 6.4. Managing External Relations

Definition: Representing the organization with external organizations such as working with customers, representing the company in a professional group, serving on a standards board, working with the media, or serving as a government liaison.

Limited Experience: Representing the organization with external customers or organizations through attendance or presentations. Attending meetings with external groups, but the position doesn't include a leadership role or serving as an official representative of the company. The experience doesn't include the development and nurturing of ongoing relationships. The experience is short-term (e.g., lasts less than one year).

Moderate Experience: Ongoing interaction with one or more external groups as a representative of the organization with the goal of building ongoing relationships. The relationship is important to the organization's success and includes specific outcomes to be achieved. The experience lasts more than a year.

Deep Experience: Serving as primary point of contact responsible for building ongoing relationships with key external groups (e.g., customers, government agencies). The position directly impacts organizational strategy and investment decisions. The position lasts for three or more years.

lead a project team, manage the budget for your team, or launch a new product.”). Encourage managers to hold two separate conversations with their employees—one focused on performance goals for the year and a second focusing on development goals. Ideally, these should occur at different points in the year; but at a minimum, encourage managers to schedule two separate meetings (perhaps even noting that devoting one hour a year to an employee's development is a pretty small investment considering the potential payoff for the employee and the organization).

All of these ideas are good, but are unlikely to lead to an organization-wide impact if they fail to incorporate the design principles discussed earlier. For example, the list of on-the-job development ideas should be a self-contained tool and readily

accessible to all employees (e.g., on a web page or as an Adobe .pdf file that is posted online) so that it is easy for people to access and pass on to others (simple, sneeze-able). Once created, the tools can be pushed so they appear “just in time” when leaders and employees need them, such as live links in the development plan instructions (systemic). Managers should have easy access to the ideas as they are preparing for development planning discussions with their employees (systemic). URL links to the tools should be provided in the development planning tools on the pages where they are needed. The developmental assignments should be in business language, not HR language (simple) and with actions that combine doing the job and developing oneself at the same time (strategic).

People, Networks, and Learning Communities

People in a leader’s network play a critical role in his or her development. They serve as role models, mentors, peer coaches, and feedback sources and provide social support. Leadership by its very nature requires getting things done through other people, managing diversity, and influencing others. Much of the development via other people happens informally. For example, in a study asking people to identify key career conversations, Kidd, Hirsh, and Jackson (2004) found that only 7 percent took place in the performance management or development planning process and only 21 percent were with a boss. Mentoring research suggests a similar finding: informal mentoring relationships are often more effective than formal ones (Chao, Walz, & Gardner, 1992; Ragins & Cotton, 1999). The challenge then becomes how to launch formal systems that incorporate the characteristics of informal mentoring relationships (Allen, Finkelstein, & Poteet, 2009; Ragins & Kram, 2007).

Strategies might include creating a pool of mentors so mentees can choose who they want, building peer coaching into training programs, linking new employees with experienced peers who can serve as mentors, sponsoring affinity groups that address gaps in employee development (e.g., women in leadership), or creating organizationally sponsored communities of practice composed of people who share common interests that meet

regularly to share ideas and best practices. All of these are good ideas, but the challenge is building the relationship interventions so they are sustainable and build energy over time.

Communities of practice serve as a prime example. Defined as “groups of people informally bound together by shared expertise and passion for joint enterprise” (Wenger & Snyder, 2000, p. 139), they can exist inside one organization or span multiple organizations. Their primary purpose is to stimulate personal development and help organizations harness informal networks (McDermott & Archibald, 2010). However, like any other intervention, communities of practice are not guaranteed to accomplish their anticipated goals (Kirkman, Mathieu, Cordery, Rosen, & Kukenberger, 2011; Roberts, 2006). Several conditions are necessary to build sustainable communities of practice (Kirkman, Mathieu, Cordery, Rosen, & Kukenberger, 2011; McDermott & Archibald, 2010; Wenger, McDermott, & Snyder, 2002). A substantial number of them fall within the five design characteristics discussed thus far. For example, communities are more likely to survive when senior leaders serve as sponsors of the practice communities (strategy).

Pilot groups can be sponsored and used as models for other groups just getting started (simple, sneeze-able, systemic). Communities of practice can be encouraged to build structures that are self-sustaining, with shared leadership, ongoing activities to engage active participants (sustainable), and easy on-boarding opportunities for outsiders to join the communities (sneeze-able). Taken together, this paints a picture of system-wide people development. The process might start with one initiative or one community, but it has the potential to gain momentum and grow because of how it is designed.

Conclusion

The field has come a long way since *Lessons of Experience* (McCall, Lombardo, & Morrison, 1988) was published twenty-five years ago. I-O and HR professionals are much more cognizant of the critical role that experience plays in the development of leaders. In some corners, 70–20–10 development has become a buzzword. Some talent management processes, such as succession

management, are based on the idea of experience-based development, even though in many companies it continues to be more role-based than experience-based.

The next frontier for the field is to make experience-based development as much of an integrating element in talent management systems as competency models are today. The key message is that, in today's organizations, on-the-job development initiatives will only meet this challenge if I-O and HR professionals are able to find ways to take advantage of the dynamic, highly networked organizations that will be typical of the 21st century to craft on-the-job development interventions that gain energy over time.

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